Sony woes
As if the PS3 network hacking wasn't enough, the Xbox 360 has outsold the PS3 in the US, despite price cut of the latter

Huawei tablets in India
Huawei is set to launch its 7-inch Android 3.2 tablets in the Indian market in October

Kinect isn't just a console accompaniment. It has the potential to unlock fun new ways of human-machine interaction.

Kinect Hacking: A Beginner's Guide

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Microsoft launched the Kinect motion sensing controller for Xbox 360 last year and it landed in the Guinness Book of World Records as the "fastest selling consumer device" of all-time, selling over 10 million units in just two months. While the PlayStation Move and Nintendo Wii require you to hold a wand or pointing stick to use gestures to manipulate the respective consoles, Microsoft's Kinect requires no such thing, strongly emphasising on its "you are the controller" tagline in adverts. So how has this simple-looking device shaken the world of gaming (and personal technology sector to some extent) to become a revolution of sorts? Well, much credit goes to Microsoft and plain old human ingenuity.

We got in touch with Harishankar Narayanan, a Chennai-based game developer who likes tinkering with gadgets. After hopping on to the Kinect bandwagon, he wasted no time in recognising the potential of the tool and – after hacking it – developed a unique, personalised solution for his needs. Here's his story.

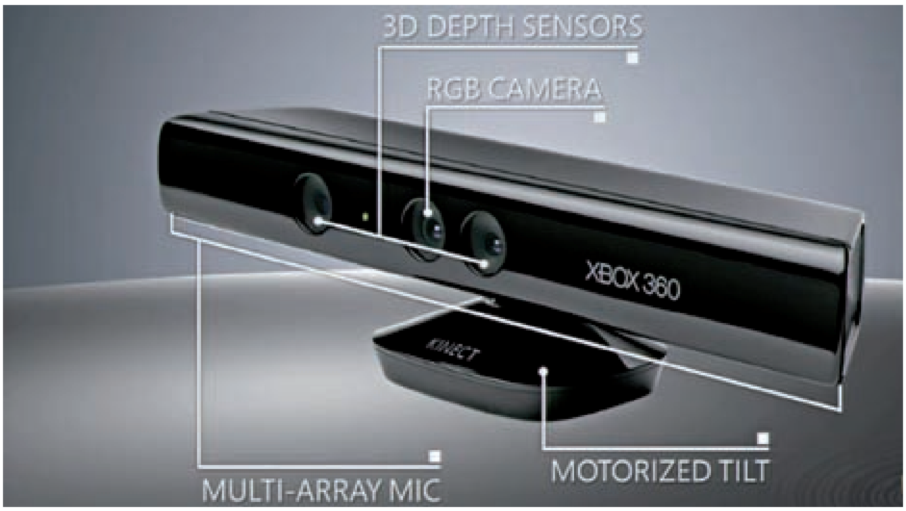
HOW DOES IT WORK?

To simply put it, Microsoft's Kinect is just an advanced camera that can do more than the normal web cameras we're accustomed to. For instance, a normal web camera scans an array of colours in front of the lens, and each pixel provides the colour information (red, green and blue values) of the objects in front of it.

Kinect, however, is designed to give you information on the distance between the camera and each pixel target in addition to the aforementioned colour values. With this information, computers can now guess how far each object is from the camera. To top it off, Kinect also has four microphones that can detect the origin of sounds.

HOW DOES KINECT MEASURE DEPTH?

The Kinect has three main inbuilt components. a normal VGA colour camera (CMOS), an infrared projector and infrared scanning camera. The VGA camera is nothing but a web camera that



Here's a pic that highlights the main aspects of Kinect. It has a 3D depth sensor, RGB camera, motorized tilt and a multi-array mic.